

when we do, it always becomes the number one product. Everything we do is about speed, scale, flexibility and then replicative. The future is all about what our kids understand on social networking, collaboration and teamwork; how we use video and the power of Internet, wired and wireless, to change everything from productivity to healthcare to education. It is about new business models.

It is a new decade with great expectations but I think these expectations actually may be pretty conservative because these are based on incremental improvements. We must have the ability to catch market transitions, understand how these new technologies will transform education for ever. You can develop the ability to educate an average citizen in India at perhaps \$1 a month or the capability to have a doctor visit you

"FOR A DOLLAR PER MONTH PER STUDENT, COMPETITIVE EDUCATION CAN BE GIVEN TO THE YOUNG PEOPLE IN INDIA."

JOHN CHAMBERS

and charge \$1 per visit. You must be able to do that virtually, as if you are in the same room when you could be at any location throughout the country. It is the chance to catch these transitions and lead that matters. Change is going to happen to us all. There are individuals, companies and countries who have the courage to embrace the change even though it makes them uncomfortable. The ingredients that determine the success of countries are same everywhere. All of them that have a great future, a great education system that is inclusive, otherwise you would not have political stability. But they are also able to build the infrastructure for the future, not the past. Roads, highways, water, electricity—all of this is important, but in this country, perhaps more than other countries, it is the technology that allows people to participate in an active way. The future of this country is about how effective is your

broadband infrastructure. Do you build the best highways in the world for the future, for all your citizens? And do you catch this transition around video? This is how businesses will be run, how we will communicate with our families, give directions, push issues of common interest to several groups. The challenge is to have these groups work together and at a much faster pace. I not only see India as the workforce of the world, virtually and physically, but as mentioned earlier I see it as an innovation engine. Many of our creative ideas are coming out of this market and going straight into the developed world.

So how do we leverage these market transitions more effectively? How do you connect to these communities when 500 million people in the next five years will be relocated to cities? How do you take your virtual cities and not only create education and healthcare there, but create jobs to go with it? Why am I in India? It's the talent, it's the ability to combine new forms of business models in education, in collaboration with the government, with the power of video. The doctor diagnoses over the Internet, it's a model for what can be done in this country. Sample this: a teacher communicating curriculum to students, the ability to share the teacher across five poor schools in a day as opposed to one teacher trying to teach all the topics to the students—the ability to connect to your best teachers. The network is the platform for communication and interaction. It is this capability that will enable not just society change, it will also raise productivity which developed countries must have to increase the standard of living. When you think of India about five years ago, you think about different price points and different economic models. When you think of India's population, with the power of the Internet, it is within our grasp to enable every student in India to have a competitive education at a cheaper cost. The future is about video and collaboration.

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D I S C U S S I O N

Q. Can you tell us more about these virtual universities, about \$1 per student?

A. During a professor's lecture, the formatting follows the camera around, so you could have two locations or 300. One of the locations is in India and this will work at the university level. We need to train our teachers in this technology and deliver virtually over backroom broadband capability. I would say let's set an unreasonable goal of \$1 per month for education. But if you don't build up your national

broadband, this will not work.

Q. How can we take your dream through all those grids and sell it to various agencies, the Centre, state governments and the private players?

A. Take a step back, paint the vision of what you want to do and then set top three priorities: collaboration, video and virtualisation. So then it starts with groups, from the government, business, academia to state, local as well as national level. The challenge is to do this in a particular time frame.

Q. My name is Koel Purie and I am a chat show host. Should I be looking at doing my show virtually because from the way that you are talking about things, everything will be moving away from one-on-one contact?

A. It will be a combination of the two and if you watch what is going on, 90 per cent of the nodes on networks are user-generated. The key is how do you do both. How do you take advantage of the traditional way of doing it but also be able to have your video blogs patched up and your ad-

vertising models.

Q. That magic \$1 figure, what sort of infrastructure and investment does one need to get that?

A. This is where Dr Kalam got us thinking differently. What we have done in Bangalore is an example of out-of-the-box thinking. Whether it is \$2 or 50 cents, we can do it through technology. The government has to build the super highway that connects the key posts around the country. Then you can go wireless for that, bring that into every classroom, to every citizen.